

No Proof $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you can't give a good argument for P, don't believe P.

Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you cannot distinguish between a situation in which P and a situation in which not-P, do not believe P.

Proof $\rightarrow$ Belief

If you can prove P,
believe P.

Let's take stock. We've now considered three candidate rules of belief.

We've seen that both of our "no belief" principles are open to substantial challenge. But surely, one might think, there must be **some** principle which explains why certain beliefs are bad beliefs.

Pastafarianism has its uses. For example, it can be used to get a religious exemption from the rule that one cannot wear a hat in a driver's license photo:

Arizona

DRIVER LICENSE

USA

NOT FOR FEDERAL IDENTIFICATION



9 CLASS D

9e END M

12 REST NONE

1 CORBETT

2 SEAN MICHAEL

8

4b EXP

/2045

4a ISS

05/04/2017

15 SEX M

18 EYES HAZ

16 HGT 5'-07"

19 HAIR BRO

17 WGT 250 lb

DONOR ♥

/80

Signature



As you might guess, many Pastafarians take a somewhat less than serious attitude toward the tenets of Pastafarianism. But it can be used to make a serious philosophical point.

But suppose that someone were a serious Pastafarian. We would, I take it, be inclined to think that there is something irrational about their beliefs.

And this might be so even if we could not come up with any decisive argument against Pastafarianism. After all, Pastafarianism is designed so as to avoid arguments against it. When presented with such an argument, the Pastafarian will simply say that the evidence on which the argument is based is misleading, and was planted by the Flying Spaghetti Monster.

But even if this point is taken on board, it looks like conservative principles of belief can license truly crazy views. Imagine a serious Pastafarian for whom belief in the FSM is a basic belief. Or imagine a serious believer in astrology for whom astrology is a basic belief. Conservative principles say that these people should stick with these beliefs unless they encounter some good argument against them. Can this be right?

One way to defend conservative principles is to say that this is not such a bad result, because there are in fact plenty of good arguments against theses like Pastafarianism and astrology.

For example, I believe both of the following claims.

Spaghetti is a human invention. There is no spaghetti (anywhere in the universe) which was not made by a person.

No person has ever
made any magical
spaghetti.

But these two claims would seem to rule out the existence of the FSM.

By contrast, you might think, there are no such easy arguments against the existence of God (for example).

This is enough to show that, even if Restricted Conservatism is true,
someone who believes the above claims about spaghetti should, on that
basis, discard their belief in the FSM.

But what about someone for whom belief in the FSM is basic, and who does not endorse the above claims about spaghetti? Perhaps this person has no beliefs which could be used in an argument against the FSM.

Restricted Conservatism would seem to imply that a person of this sort should maintain their Pastafarian beliefs, and that to give them up would be a mistake. Can this be correct?



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